

Word family: ****problem / problematic / problematically / problem-solving / problem-solver / problem-free****

****Base word:** problem**

****Plural:** problems**

****Related forms:** problematic, problematically**

****Useful extensions:** problem-solving, problem-solver, problem-free**

****Part of speech:** noun (名詞) / adjective-related forms (相關形容詞)**

Your sentence:

> “Overall, that advertisement was persuasive because it solved a real ****problem**** and made the product seem useful, comforting, and luxurious.”

A semantic note first: ****problem** has one strong central concept—something that creates difficulty, causes harm, or requires an answer—but it develops several important contextual uses. ****** We should keep those connected rather than artificially treating every context as unrelated.

Meaning in this passage

Here, ****problem**** means:

****a genuine practical difficulty in everyday life that needed to be dealt with—in this case, noise during commuting or travelling.****

****繁體中文:** **現實生活中真實存在、會造成不便或困擾, 因此需要解決的實際困難****

Natural translation:

> “It solved a real problem.”

「它****解決了一個真實存在的實際問題****。」

Here:

****real problem = 並非想像或人為製造, 而是在日常生活中確實存在並造成困擾的問題****

1. ****problem = difficulty that needs to be dealt with (困難／麻煩) — 問題; 困難****

This is your original meaning.

Practice 1 — Original

> “It solved a real **problem**.”

「它解決了一個真實存在的**實際問題**。」

Practice 2

> “Noise is a serious **problem** in open-plan offices.”

「噪音是開放式辦公室中一個嚴重的**問題／困擾**。」

Practice 3

> “We need to deal with the **problem** before it gets worse.”

「我們需要在情況惡化之前處理這個**問題**。」

problem = 會造成困難、不便、損害或障礙, 因此需要採取行動處理的情況

2. **problem** = question/task requiring an answer (題目／難題) — 題目; 問題; 難題

Meaning: A question or task that must be worked out logically or mathematically.

Practice 4

> “The students solved the maths **problem**.”

「學生解答了那道數學**題目**。」

Practice 5

> “This logic **problem** is harder than it looks.”

「這道邏輯**難題**比看起來更困難。」

problem = 需要透過計算、推理或分析找出答案的題目／難題

This is why English naturally says:

> **solve a problem**

for both:

- * practical problems
- * mathematical problems

3. **problem = cause of trouble/fault(故障／原因) — 毛病;故障;問題所在**

Meaning: Something wrong in a machine, system, process, or situation.

Practice 6

> “There is a **problem** with the battery.”

「電池**出了問題／有故障**。」

Practice 7

> “The technician found the **problem**.”

「技術人員找到了**問題所在／故障原因**。」

problem = 系統、設備或程序中出現的不正常情況、缺陷或故障原因

4. **problem with + person/thing/situation(對象／情況) — 對.....有問題;不滿／難以接受**

This can refer to dissatisfaction, objection, or difficulty.

Practice 8

> “I have a **problem with** the way this was handled.”

「我對這件事的處理方式**有意見／不能完全接受**。」

Practice 9

> “Do you have a **problem with** this arrangement?”

「你對這個安排**有問題／有甚麼不滿嗎**？」

have a problem with something = 對某件事感到不滿、不接受, 或認為其中存在問題

Context decides whether it means:

- * practical difficulty
- * objection
- * dislike

5. **have a problem doing + action (做某事有困難) — 難以……; 做……有困難**

Practice 10

> “I have a **problem concentrating** in noisy places.”

「我在嘈雜的地方**很難集中精神**。」

Practice 11

> “She had no **problem finding** the hotel.”

「她**毫不費力就找到**了酒店。」

have a problem doing something = 做某件事時遇到困難

And:

> **have no problem doing something**

= **做某事沒有困難／完全沒問題**

6. **no problem = no difficulty / acceptable (回應) — 沒問題; 可以**

A very common conversational expression.

Practice 12

> “Can you help me with this?”

> “**No problem.**”

「你可以幫我處理這件事嗎？」

「**沒問題.**」

Practice 13

> “Can I change the booking?”

> “Sure, **no problem**.”

「我可以更改預訂嗎？」

「當然, **沒問題**。」

no problem = 表示某件事不困難、可以接受或願意幫忙

7. **no problem = you're welcome / don't worry about it — 不客氣; 不用放在心上**

A second conversational function.

Practice 14

> “Thanks for your help.”

> “**No problem.**”

「謝謝你的幫忙。」

「**不客氣／沒事**。」

Practice 15

> “Sorry I'm late.”

> “**No problem.**”

「不好意思, 我遲到了。」

「**沒關係**。」

no problem = 用來回應感謝或道歉, 表示事情沒有造成困擾

Same expression, different conversational function.

8. **problem = person/thing causing repeated difficulty — 麻煩來源; 問題人物／問題事物**

Practice 16

> “The old printer has become a constant **problem**.”

「那部舊打印機已經變成一個持續的**麻煩來源**。」

Practice 17

> “Poor communication is the main **problem**.”

「溝通不良才是主要的**問題所在**。」

problem = 持續造成困難、錯誤或麻煩的人／事物／因素

9. **social/economic/environmental problem (社會／經濟／環境) — 問題; 社會難題**

Practice 18

> “Housing affordability is a major social **problem**.”

「住屋負擔能力是一個重大的社會**問題**。」

Practice 19

> “Pollution remains a serious environmental **problem**.”

「污染仍然是一個嚴重的環境**問題**。」

problem = 影響大量人口、制度或環境, 需要政策或集體行動處理的困難

This is still the same core sense, just larger in scale.

10. **health/medical problem (健康／醫療) — 健康問題; 毛病**

Practice 20

> “He has a minor back **problem**.”

「他的背部有一點**毛病／健康問題**。」

Practice 21

> “Sleep **problems** can affect concentration.”

「睡眠**問題**可能影響專注力。」

****problem — health = 身體或心理功能出現異常、困擾或需要處理的狀況****

11. ****problem = issue in research/philosophy/science (研究／哲學／科學) — 問題; 研究難題****

Practice 22

> “The researchers are studying the ****problem**** of data bias.”

「研究人員正在研究數據偏差這個****問題****。」

Practice 23

> “The mind-body ****problem**** has been discussed for centuries.”

「心身****問題****已經被討論了數百年。」

****problem = 尚未完全解決、需要深入分析或解釋的理論性／研究性難題****

12. ****problematic = causing difficulties / open to criticism — 有問題的; 棘手的; 值得質疑的****

This is an important family member.

Practice 24

> “The design is ****problematic**** for older users.”

「這個設計對年長使用者來說****存在不少問題／使用上很棘手****。」

Practice 25

> “That assumption is ****problematic****.”

「那個假設****有問題／值得質疑****。」

****problematic = 因存在缺陷、風險、矛盾或負面影響而需要注意／質疑的****

Important: ****problematic**** does not simply mean “difficult.” It often implies:

> **there is something questionable or wrong with it**

13. **problematically** = in a way that creates difficulties or concerns — 有問題地; 以引起問題的方式

This word exists but is less common.

Practice 26

> “The rule is **problematically** vague.”

「這項規則**模糊得會造成問題**。」

Practice 27

> “The data were **problematically** incomplete.”

「這些數據**不完整到會影響判斷**。」

problematically = 以會造成困難、疑慮或可靠性問題的方式

For ordinary English, speakers often prefer:

> “in a problematic way”

14. **problem-solving** = process/skill of finding solutions — 解決問題; 問題解決能力

You saw this in the **solve** family, but it also belongs naturally here as a compound extension.

Practice 28

> “Good managers need strong **problem-solving skills**.”

「好的經理需要很強的**問題解決能力**。」

Practice 29

> “The course focuses on creative **problem-solving**.”

「這個課程著重培養創意**解決問題能力**。」

****problem-solving = 分析問題、找出原因並發展有效解決方法的過程或能力****

15. ****problem-solver = person/system good at solving problems — 擅長解決問題的人／系統****

Practice 30

> “She is an excellent ****problem-solver****.”

「她是一個非常擅長****解決問題的人****。」

Practice 31

> “The company wants employees who are independent ****problem-solvers****.”

「公司希望員工能夠成為獨立的****問題解決者****。」

****problem-solver = 能分析困難並找出有效解決方案的人、工具或系統****

16. ****problem-free = without difficulties or faults — 沒有問題的；順利的****

Practice 32

> “The installation was completely ****problem-free****.”

「安裝過程完全****沒有出現問題，非常順利****。」

Practice 33

> “We had a ****problem-free**** journey.”

「我們有一趟****非常順利、沒有任何問題的旅程****。」

****problem-free = 沒有出現故障、困難或麻煩的****

Important distinction: ****problem vs issue****

They overlap a lot.

problem

usually more clearly means:

something is wrong and needs fixing

> “We have a problem with the battery.”

「電池出了問題。」

issue

can mean:

* problem;

* topic/question for discussion.

> “We discussed the issue of privacy.”

「我們討論了私隱這個議題。」

So **issue** can sound more neutral.

In workplace English, people sometimes use **issue** instead of **problem** because it sounds less negative:

> “There’s a technical issue.”

instead of:

> “There’s a technical problem.”

Important distinction: **problem vs difficulty**

problem

= something that needs an answer/solution

difficulty

= something that makes an action hard

> “The main problem is noise.”

「主要問題是噪音。」

> “I had difficulty concentrating.”

「我很難集中精神。」

A **difficulty** may become a **problem**, but the emphasis differs.

Important distinction: **problem** vs **trouble**

problem

neutral and broad.

trouble

often means difficulty, inconvenience, danger, or problems generally.

> “I had trouble sleeping.”

「我睡不著／我睡眠有困難。」

> “The machine is causing problems.”

「這部機器正在造成問題。」

trouble is usually uncountable in this sense:

> “I had trouble...” 

not normally:

> “a trouble” 

Important distinction: **problem** vs **question**

This matters especially in school and academic English.

question

asks for information/an answer.

problem

often requires reasoning, calculation, or a practical solution.

> “Answer the question.”

「回答問題。」

> “Solve the problem.”

「解決／解答難題。」

So:

answer a question

solve a problem

is the standard pairing.

Important distinction: **problem vs challenge**

problem

emphasizes something wrong, difficult, or undesirable.

challenge

often presents difficulty more positively, as something that can test ability or encourage improvement.

> “Noise is a problem.”

「噪音是一個問題。」

> “Learning a new language is a challenge.”

「學習新語言是一項挑戰。」

Business language sometimes calls a **problem** a **challenge** to sound more constructive.

Important distinction: **problem vs obstacle**

problem

= broad difficulty requiring a solution

obstacle

= something specifically blocking progress toward a goal

> “Cost is a major obstacle.”

「成本是一大障礙。」

An obstacle is a type of problem, but emphasizes **blocking progress**.

Important distinction: **problematic vs difficult**

difficult

= hard to do/deal with

problematic

= contains problems, flaws, risks, or questionable aspects

Compare:

> “The calculation is difficult.”

「這個計算很難。」

> “The method is problematic.”

「這個方法本身有問題／存在缺陷。」

They are not interchangeable.

Grammar note: **problem with / problem of**

problem with + thing/person

often identifies what is malfunctioning or objectionable:

> “There is a problem **with the screen**.”

「屏幕出了問題。」

problem of + broader issue

often introduces a general phenomenon:

> “the problem **of pollution**”

「污染問題」

Both patterns are useful, but they frame the problem differently.

Grammar note: **have trouble vs have a problem**

> “I have a problem concentrating.”

Possible, but can sound like there is a specific recurring issue.

> “I have trouble concentrating.”

Very natural for:

**我很難集中精神。*

So:

have trouble doing = 做某事有困難

have a problem with = 對某件事有問題／某物出了問題

Family-extension sweep

After the full family sweep, the genuinely useful modern family is:

* **problem** = 問題; 困難; 故障; 難題
 * **problem with** =出了問題／對.....有意見
 * **have a problem doing** = 做.....有困難
 * **no problem** = 沒問題; 不客氣; 沒關係
 * **problematic** = 有問題的; 值得質疑的
 * **problematically** = 以會造成問題的方式
 * **problem-solving** = 解決問題／問題解決能力
 * **problem-solver** = 擅長解決問題的人／工具
 * **problem-free** = 沒有問題的; 順利的

I would **not** inflate the family with rare forms that normal learners are unlikely to need.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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problem — practical difficulty	會造成不便、困難或障礙, 因此需要採取行動處理的情況
problem — question/task	需要透過計算、推理或分析找出答案的題目／難題
problem — fault	設備、系統或程序中出現的不正常情況、缺陷或故障原因
problem with something	某物存在故障／缺陷, 或說話者對某事不滿、不能接受
have a problem doing	做某件事時遇到明顯困難
no problem — permission/help	表示某件事可以做到、沒有困難或願意幫忙
no problem — response	回應感謝／道歉時表示不客氣或沒關係
problem — source of trouble	持續造成錯誤、困難或麻煩的人／事物／因素
social/environmental problem	影響大量人口、制度或環境, 需要集體處理的困難
medical problem	身體或心理功能出現異常、困擾或需要處理的狀況
research problem	尚未完全解決、需要分析或解釋的理論／研究難題
problematic	因存在缺陷、風險、矛盾或疑點而需要注意或質疑的
problem-solving	分析問題並找出有效解決方案的過程／能力
problem-solver	能分析困難並找出有效解決辦法的人、工具或系統
problem-free	沒有出現故障、困難或麻煩的

For your original sentence

> “Overall, that advertisement was persuasive because it solved a real **problem**...”

The exact meaning is:

problem = 說話者日常生活中確實遇到、會造成困擾並需要解決的實際困難

In this passage, that problem is:

****嘈雜的通勤／旅行環境，令人疲累或難以集中精神。****

So:

> ****a real problem****

= ****「一個真實存在的實際問題／現實生活中的困擾」****